student activities can have during the years from adolescence to adulthood.

If I had gone to one of those larger schools, I think I would have fallen back in the crowd and never discovered things about myself that I did at Eureka. My life would have been different.

There were fewer than 250 students when I was at Eureka, roughly divided between men and women, and everyone knew one another by their first name.

As in a small town, you couldn’t remain anonymous at a small college. Everybody was needed. Whether it’s the glee club or helping to edit the school yearbook, there’s a job for everyone, and everybody gets a chance to shine at something and build their sense of self-confidence. You get to discover things about yourself that you might never learn if you were lost in the crowd of a larger school.

I’ve been accused of majoring in extracurricular activities at Eureka. Technically, that wasn’t true. My major was economics. But it is true I thrived on school activities—although my expectation of sweeping onto the campus and becoming an overnight football sensation was, to say the least, not fulfilled.

Our coach, Mac McKinzie, was a legend at Eureka who as a student had won twelve letters and been the captain of his team in three sports. During one football game, he single-handedly scored all the points and beat our archrival, Bradley Tech, 52—0, and while he was still a student, he was elected assistant coach of the football team and, shortly thereafter, head coach.

Legend or not, I soon reached the conclusion that Mac McKinzie didn’t like me. He was not only unimpressed by my high school exploits, he kept me on the bench most of the season and I spent much of my freshman year sulking about it.